

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 1168

By Bailey

A RESOLUTION to honor Mary Denise McNeal on her distinguished service to the State of Tennessee on the occasion of her retirement from the District Public Defender's Office for the 13th Judicial District.

WHEREAS, it is appropriate that the members of this General Assembly should honor those citizens who have performed with uncommon devotion and enthusiasm through their careers in public service; and

WHEREAS, one such estimable person is Mary Denise McNeal, a longtime resident of Putnam County, who has faithfully served the citizens of the State of Tennessee since 2001 as an employee of the District Public Defender's Office for the 13th Judicial District; and

WHEREAS, Denise McNeal began her career with the District Public Defender's Office for the 13th Judicial District as a legal assistant and, through her diligence, skill, and leadership, rose to serve as office manager, a role in which she became essential to the effective operation of the office; and

WHEREAS, throughout her tenure, Ms. McNeal has been a constant and trusted presence, providing invaluable support to attorneys, staff, and clients, and ensuring that the daily work of the office is carried out with efficiency and care; and

WHEREAS, Ms. McNeal's institutional knowledge, strong work ethic, and attention to detail have made her an indispensable member of the office, and her willingness to assist others has left a lasting mark on colleagues both past and present; and

WHEREAS, she has generously shared her experience with new employees, offering guidance, patience, and practical wisdom, thereby strengthening the office as a whole; and

WHEREAS, beyond her professional accomplishments, Denise McNeal is known for her compassion and dedication outside the workplace, particularly her deep commitment to animal

welfare, as an active supporter of rescue and foster organizations, including Safe Haven Puppy Sanctuary, A.A.R.F. (All About Rescue and Fixin' Inc.), and others, reflecting a spirit of care and service that extends well beyond her official duties; and

WHEREAS, Denise McNeal's humor, steady presence, and remarkable efficiency will be deeply missed by her colleagues, by the Conference Office with whom she worked closely over the years, and perhaps most notably by Bella, the office dog, who found both comfort and companionship napping in her office; and

WHEREAS, Denise McNeal's retirement, effective July 31, 2026, marks the conclusion of a distinguished career in public service and the beginning of a well-earned new chapter; and

WHEREAS, throughout her estimable career, Mary Denise McNeal has demonstrated the utmost professionalism, ability, and integrity, winning the unbridled respect and admiration of the members of the bar and bench and her community alike; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor and commend Mary Denise McNeal for her years of dedicated and astute service with the District Public Defender's Office for the 13th Judicial District and extend to her our best wishes for a retirement filled with happiness, good health, and continued purpose.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.